BRAND CASE STUDY

Why Percy Pig Works

How M&S turned a sweet into a brand

Eila Hemmings | October 2026

THE QUESTION

Why does one sweet become a brand?

Percy Pig began in the early 1990s as a piggy-shaped gummy sweet. Today he is described as one of M&S Food's most valuable assets. Three things explain why.

1. Character

People connect with a personality, not a pack.

2. Range

New products stretch the brand without losing the core.

3. Loyalty

Fans care enough that M&S protects the design.

Source: Creative Review, "An oral history of Percy Pig"

THE SCALE

This is no niche sweet

20m

packs sold a year, as reported by Creative Review

400m

individual sweets a year

50+

Percy items on the M&S website, from sweets to bedding

A sweet that sells at this scale is no longer a checkout treat. It is a category driver for M&S Food.

Sources: Creative Review; The Star (Percy's 30th birthday coverage)

REASON 1: CHARACTER

He is a character, not just a product

2020

Percy joins TikTok, and his antics rack up millions of views.

TV debut

He stars in the M&S Christmas Food ad, voiced by Tom Holland.

30th birthday

He gets his own pink plaque at the Paddington food hall.

A personality gives customers something to follow, share and talk about. A bag of sweets alone does not.

Sources: Creative Review; The Star (Percy's 30th birthday coverage)

REASON 2: RANGE

The range keeps stretching

Core sweets

12 types of Percy sweets at his 30th birthday, from Party Time Percy to Percy and Pals.

New categories

Bedding, jigsaws, dog jumpers and baking mixes all carry the Percy name.

Collaborations

A Nails Inc set was pitched at Percy “superfans”.

M&S’s stated plan is to explore new categories while protecting and growing the core products.

Sources: Marketing Week; The Star (Percy’s 30th birthday coverage)

REASON 3: LOYALTY

Fans care, and M&S protects the brand

Fan devotion

M&S's court filing cited a customer who had Percy's face tattooed.

Protected design

Swizzels agreed to redesign a rival sweet after M&S argued shoppers could confuse the two.

Inclusive recipe

Every Percy sweet has been gelatine-free since May 2019.

Loyalty this strong is worth defending, and M&S treats the brand's look as an asset to protect.

Sources: Retail Gazette; The Guardian; Wikipedia

BEYOND THE UK

Percy is going global

United States

Over 50,000 bags of Percy Pigs a week sell through Target.

Australia

Percy Pig is part of the M&S Food range now sold in Coles supermarkets.

150+ countries

In 2021, M&S began selling food online to over 150 new countries.

Customers abroad asked when Percy would arrive. Strong demand makes him an easy product to export.

Sources: ESM Magazine; Retail Times

MY RECOMMENDATIONS

What M&S can learn from Percy

Protect the core

Keep the sweets' quality and taste first. Every extension borrows trust from them.

Extend with discipline

Trial new categories as limited editions, and keep only those that fit the brand.

Let data decide

Track which launches add sales rather than just moving them from the core range.

Percy works because character, range and loyalty reinforce each other. Other M&S Food brands could follow the same pattern.

Why percy

I grew up with Percy Pig, and because pigs are my favourite animal, I've always felt a real connection to the brand that goes beyond the sweets. That connection makes me more likely to buy his other merchandise, not just the sweets themselves. I think this is a very good idea, because it turns a much-loved product into a character people want to collect and keep buying. It's also why I chose to study Percy Pig, since I'm a real example of how M&S has built a brand that customers love.

Ssources

- Creative Review: An oral history of Percy Pig
- The Star: Percy Pig turns 30
- Marketing Week: M&S ramps up brand character focus
- Retail Gazette: Swizzels agrees to redesign rival sweets
- The Guardian: Swizzels agrees to change design
- Wikipedia: Percy Pig
- ESM Magazine: M&S food range in Australia with Coles
- Retail Times: M&S Food launches in Coles
- ESM Magazine: M&S sells in over 150 countries